FREE GUIDE · THE OP TEAM

BUYING A HOME IN VAUGHAN

The 15 steps from deciding to buy to getting your keys, with a checklist for each one.



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STEP 1 OF 15

KNOW YOUR WHY

Your reason decides what to look for.

More space, a better school, a shorter commute, a first home: your reason tells us what to look for and what to skip.

Write down your must-haves and your nice-to-haves before you start.

- [ ] Why are you moving?
- [ ] When do you need to be in?
- [ ] Your must-haves: bedrooms, area, schools, parking
- [ ] Your nice-to-haves

STEP 2 OF 15

INTERVIEW REALTORS

Find someone who works for you.

Meet two or three agents. Ask how they help buyers win in multiple offers and how they will keep you updated.

In Ontario you sign a written buyer representation agreement with your agent, so understand it before you sign.

- [ ] How many buyers have you helped in this area?
- [ ] How do you win in a bidding war?
- [ ] How will you find homes before they hit the market?
- [ ] How does your fee work?

> **MICHAEL'S TIP:** Michael holds the ABR® designation, Accredited Buyer Representative, with training focused on buyers.

STEP 3 OF 15

GET PRE-APPROVED

Know your budget before you fall in love.

A lender checks your income, debts and credit and confirms how much you can borrow. Many will hold a rate for up to 120 days.

Lenders also test whether you could afford payments at a higher rate (the stress test), so your budget may be lower than you expect.

- [ ] Gather pay stubs, tax returns and bank statements
- [ ] Talk to a bank and a mortgage broker
- [ ] Get your pre-approval in writing
- [ ] Know your monthly comfort zone, not just the maximum

STEP 4 OF 15

KNOW YOUR CLOSING COSTS

Budget for more than the down payment.

Plan for about 2% of the price on top of your down payment. Most of it is Ontario land transfer tax: about $22,500 on a $1.3 million home in Vaughan.

In Toronto you also pay a municipal land transfer tax. First-time buyers can get up to $4,000 back from Ontario, plus up to $4,475 from Toronto.

- [ ] Land transfer tax
- [ ] Legal fees and title insurance
- [ ] Home inspection
- [ ] Adjustments for prepaid property tax
- [ ] Moving costs

STEP 5 OF 15

CHOOSE YOUR NEIGHBOURHOOD

Compare before you fall for a house.

Prices, schools, commute and resale value can change street by street.

Our neighbourhood guides at soldmike.com cover Woodbridge, Vellore, Kleinburg, Maple, King, Caledon, East Gwillimbury and Toronto.

- [ ] Drive the area at rush hour
- [ ] Check school boundaries with the school board
- [ ] Walk the street on a weekend
- [ ] Ask what is planned nearby

STEP 6 OF 15

TOUR HOMES

Look past the staging.

See homes in person. Staging and photos are designed to impress, so look at the bones.

Check the layout, light, roof, windows, furnace and air conditioner age, and any signs of water.

- [ ] Take photos and notes at every showing
- [ ] Open closets and look under sinks
- [ ] Ask the age of the roof, furnace and windows
- [ ] Picture your furniture in each room

STEP 7 OF 15

CHECK THE VALUE

Know what it is really worth.

Before you write an offer, we pull recent sales nearby so you know what the home is really worth.

That number guides your offer, especially in a bidding war.

- [ ] Compare sales from the last 3 to 6 months
- [ ] Adjust for size, lot, condition and parking
- [ ] Decide your top price before offer night

STEP 8 OF 15

WRITE THE OFFER

Every term is a lever.

Your offer sets the price, deposit, conditions, closing date and what is included.

In a competitive market, a clean offer with a strong deposit can beat a higher price with conditions.

- [ ] Price
- [ ] Deposit: about 5% is common in the GTA
- [ ] Conditions: financing, inspection, status certificate
- [ ] Closing date
- [ ] Inclusions

STEP 9 OF 15

NEGOTIATE

Win it at the right price.

One-on-one, we negotiate price and terms with the listing agent. In multiple offers, everyone sends their best offer and the seller chooses.

As a Real Estate Negotiation Expert (RENE), Michael builds offers that stand out without overpaying.

- [ ] Know your walk-away price
- [ ] Have your deposit ready
- [ ] Be reachable on offer night

STEP 10 OF 15

SUBMIT YOUR DEPOSIT

Usually within 24 hours.

Once your offer is accepted, your deposit goes to the listing brokerage, held in trust, usually within 24 hours.

It counts toward your down payment on closing day.

- [ ] Have the funds ready before offer night
- [ ] Use a bank draft or wire as instructed
- [ ] Keep your receipt

STEP 11 OF 15

CLEAR YOUR CONDITIONS

Each condition has a deadline.

Common conditions are financing, a home inspection and, for condos, a review of the status certificate by your lawyer. Each has a deadline, often about five business days.

If a condition is not met, you can walk away and get your deposit back.

- [ ] Send the deal to your lender right away
- [ ] Get the status certificate to your lawyer for a condo
- [ ] Book your home inspection
- [ ] Waive conditions only when you are satisfied

STEP 12 OF 15

GO FIRM

The home is yours, pending closing.

Once every condition is waived, the deal is firm. Resale homes in Ontario have no cooling-off period, so this is the point of no return.

Now it is about getting to closing.

- [ ] Send the firm deal to your lawyer
- [ ] Plan your move
- [ ] Lock in your mortgage

STEP 13 OF 15

LAWYER AND INSURANCE

Paperwork before the keys.

Your lawyer searches the title, arranges title insurance and prepares the closing documents.

Your lender needs proof of home insurance before closing day.

- [ ] Hire a real estate lawyer
- [ ] Send the down payment and closing costs to your lawyer
- [ ] Get home insurance in place
- [ ] Set up utilities for closing day

STEP 14 OF 15

FINAL WALKTHROUGH

See it again before closing.

Most offers include visits before closing. Use the last one to check everything is as agreed.

Make sure included items are there and nothing is damaged.

- [ ] Check appliances and included items
- [ ] Note anything wrong and tell us right away
- [ ] Run taps, test lights and the furnace

STEP 15 OF 15

CLOSING DAY

Funds move, the deed registers, you get the keys.

On closing day your lawyer sends the funds, the deed registers in your name and you pick up the keys.

Welcome home.

- [ ] Pick up keys as arranged with your lawyer
- [ ] Keep your closing documents somewhere safe
- [ ] Change the locks and garage codes

> **MICHAEL'S TIP:** Congratulations. When you are ready to sell one day, we will be here.

YOUR NOTES

LET'S FIND YOUR HOME

Michael helps buyers across Vaughan, Woodbridge, Kleinburg, King, Caledon and Toronto, in English and Italian.

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